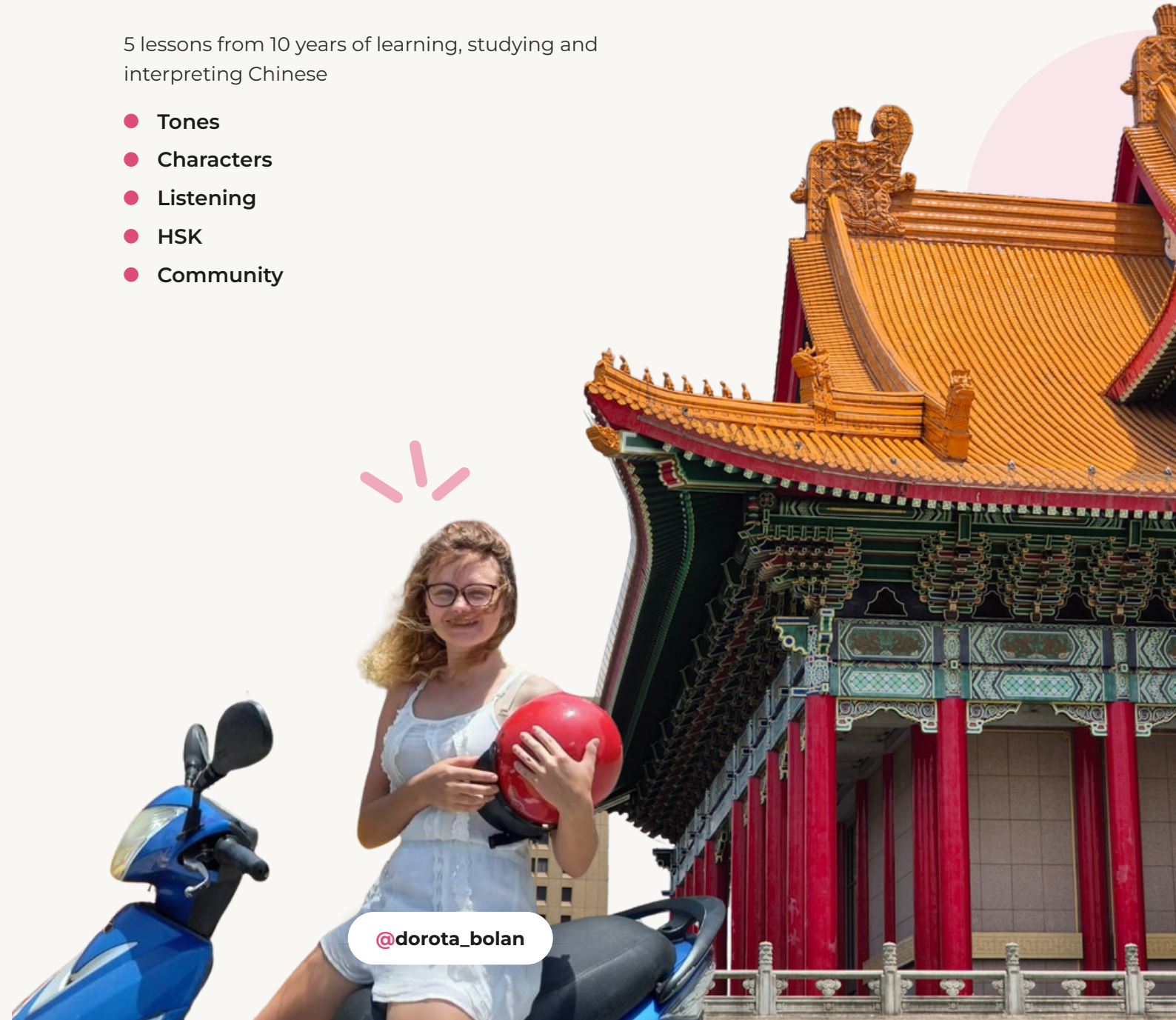
A GUIDE BY DOROTA · MANDARIN ZEST

Chinese

LEARNING ADVICE I WISH SOMEONE GAVE ME **10 YEARS AGO**

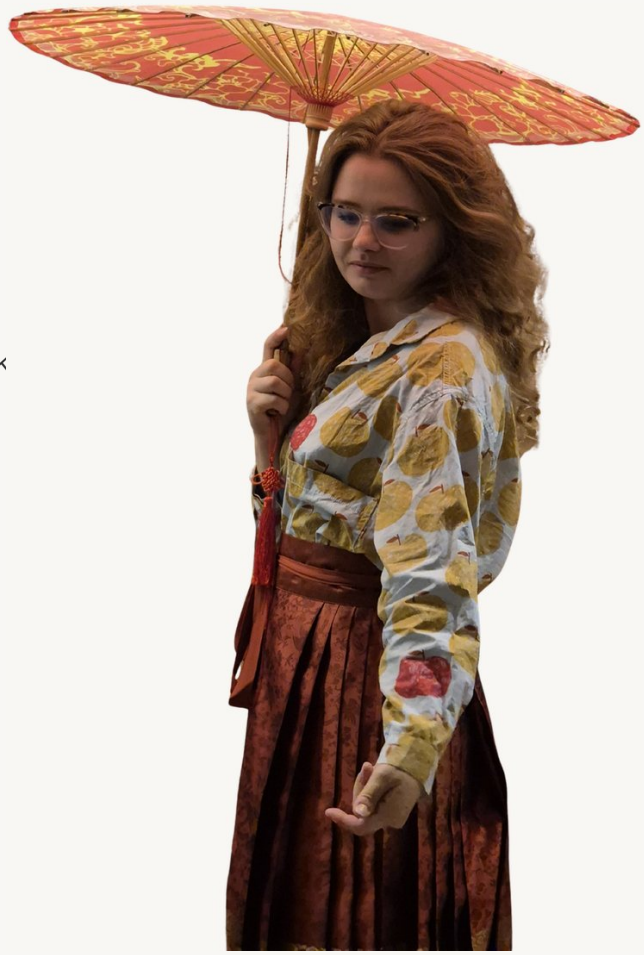
5 lessons from 10 years of learning, studying and interpreting Chinese

- **Tones**
- **Characters**
- **Listening**
- **HSK**
- **Community**



@dorota_bolan

Hi!



My name is **Dorota** and I am from Poland. **I love the Chinese language and everything related to it!** I graduated from National Taiwan University and work as a Chinese-Polish interpreter. I am one of the co-founders of the Chinese learning community **Mandarin Zest**.

When I was starting to learn Chinese over 10 years ago, it was just a hobby. I never imagined that I would get this far.

If you are like me 10 years ago, **I want you to learn from my mistakes.** I hope that you find my perspective useful.

10+
years of learning Chinese

NTU
graduate of National Taiwan University

中 ⇄ PL
Chinese-Polish interpreter

5
languages spoken

Everything you will see in this guide is what I had to learn by myself over a long period of time.

> You will find here **practical advice and an individual perspective**, not boring, AI-generated advice.

(AI helps me with design and ordering my notes, but doesn't think for me.)

I hope you will find it useful, and follow me for more tips!

Dorota

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

5 LESSONS I WISH I HAD LEARNED SOONER



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Why they make Chinese easier, and how to practise them — p. 4

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Learn the blocks, not the strokes — p. 7

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加油！

jiāyóu · keep going, you've got this

LESSON 01 · TONES

01

TONES IN CHINESE ARE VERY PRACTICAL AND MAKE COMMUNICATION EASIER.

KEY TAKEAWAY

You just have to pay a lot of attention to them in the beginning and start speaking in whole sentences as soon as you can!

When I started learning Chinese, I found the tones ridiculous, even more than the characters that seemed excessively complex to me at that time.

The idea that the entire meaning of a word or sentence could change because of such subtle pronunciation differences seemed absurd to me.

It was only later that I realised there are **so many ways in which the tones make speaking Chinese so much more practical!**



Beijing, 2015. My first time in China, and the beginning of a journey that was only just getting started.

ā
1ST · HIGH

á
2ND · RISING

ǎ
3RD · DIPPING

à
4TH · FALLING

1 First, they make things short

The same sentence written or said in English takes so much space when compared with Chinese.

ENGLISH **77 CHARACTERS**

“I love Chinese and enjoy learning something new about the language every day.”

CHINESE **21 CHARACTERS**

我很喜欢中文，也喜欢每天学习新的中文知识。

Mandarin is actually **the most concise language in the world** because of its tones and characters, meaning it can pack the most information into the most limited space possible.

2 Second, the context saves the conversation



我要买毛衣

wǒ yào mǎi máoyī · “I want to buy a sweater”

In a full sentence, this will mean “I want to buy a sweater” even if your tone on **máo** is slightly off, because **the context makes other interpretations absurd.**



Paper umbrellas in Taiwan.

However, context is not everything

People are sometimes sold the idea that tones are not a big problem as long as people can understand you, because the context will save you.



Unfortunately, I have heard it many times from native speakers: **one of the worst things to do is to disregard the tones in the beginning**, and then your Chinese just continues to be bad.

> **This is why it is very important to pay a lot of attention to tones in the beginning.**

WHAT I PERSONALLY RECOMMEND

To master the tones naturally and effectively, **don't practise them in isolation.** Start speaking whole sentences as soon as you can.

Read the characters from a piece of paper and always mark the tone above them, even when you remember the pinyin. It will help you solidify the right tones from the beginning.

zhōng qiū jié kuài lè

中秋節快樂

中秋節快樂 · Happy Mid-Autumn Festival, with every tone marked

LESSON 02 · CHARACTERS

02

CHINESE CHARACTERS ARE A LOGICAL WRITING SYSTEM MADE OF FAMILIAR COMPONENTS

KEY TAKEAWAY

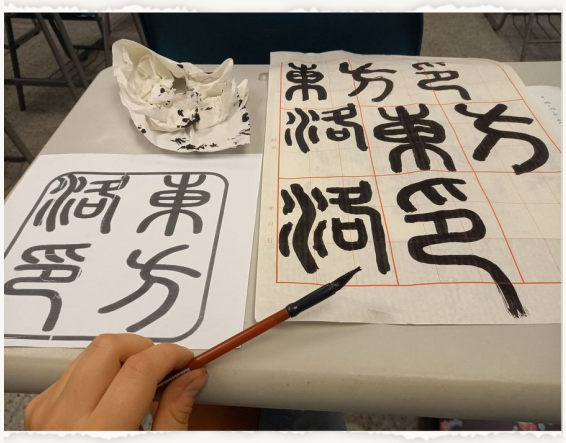
Focus on memorizing **blocks**, not strokes, and you will see they are easier than they seem!



biáng, one of the most complex characters, is built from **9 common components** you can learn one by one.

We are living in times when **practising Chinese characters is getting increasingly difficult** due to how replaceable handwriting has become. It doesn't help that most teachers don't know how to properly teach them.

When I was starting with Chinese at a Confucius Institute years ago, **I was told to handwrite and repeat**, and wait for the characters to enter my head due to this **mindless repetition.**



Writing my Chinese name at a calligraphy class in Taipei in 2021.



I blame the Chinese way of schooling: as kids, they are taught the same way. This is why **most native speakers barely understand the characters** beyond memorising them.

Chinese characters are grouped into different categories and made from familiar components that explain how they are formed and how their meaning and pronunciation are constructed.

> **Once you learn it, you will start seeing patterns, something I wish I saw years ago.**

1 Learn the correct stroke order

In the beginning, you need to learn the correct stroke order, which is easier than it sounds.

笔 PRACTISE ONLINE
Stroke order for any character
mandarinzest.com/stroke-order-information →

2 Practise writing the components first

To memorize characters efficiently, **practise writing the components at first.** You will recognize them later as you keep learning:

人 person	大 big	女 woman	子 child	山 mountain	川 river
水 water	火 fire	木 tree	日 sun	月 moon	田 field
土 earth	石 stone	雨 rain	鸟 bird	鱼 fish	马 horse
牛 ox	羊 sheep	犬 dog	虎 tiger	象 elephant	鹿 deer
兔 rabbit	鼠 rat	龟 turtle	贝 shell	刀 knife	弓 bow
门 door	户 household	口 mouth	目 eye	耳 ear	手 hand
足 foot	心 heart	身 body	车 vehicle	舟 boat	力 strength
竹 bamboo	米 rice	瓜 melon	果 fruit	衣 clothing	巾 cloth
羽 feather	血 blood	齿 tooth	面 face	首 head	爪 claw

Components like these are used to create thousands of Chinese characters.

LESSON 03 · LISTENING

03

YOUR LISTENING WILL ONLY GET BETTER WHEN YOU LISTEN. A LOT.

KEY TAKEAWAY

Listening has been one of the hardest parts of Chinese for me. That's why you need to expose yourself to it as much as possible.



Making dumplings with my host family in Beijing, 2015.

I remember how **incredibly frustrating** listening in Chinese felt to me. Even when I could already communicate quite well, listening to conversations was extremely difficult.

I sometimes still find it hard to understand some films or TV broadcasts in Chinese. The speed and the more complicated words they use feel **challenging to me even after 10 years** of learning and working as an interpreter.

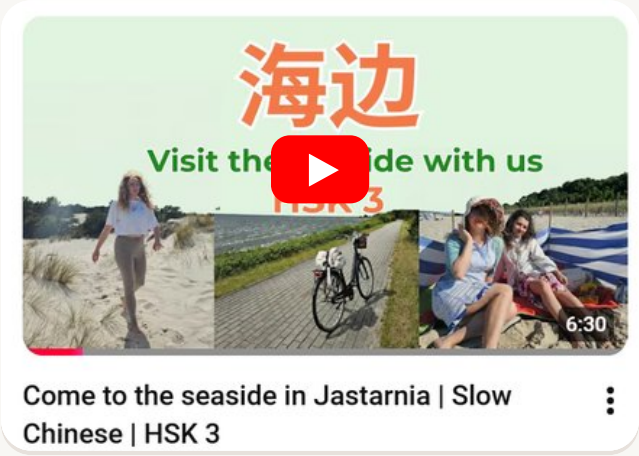


Interpreting at the Taipei Book Expo in 2023.

> **After all those years, I realized that the best way to get better at listening is to listen more.**

Luckily for us, there is so much content available online for free that it has never been easier to practise.

That's why I recommend **regularly watching videos in Chinese.** Speaking of which, I also like to record such videos on YouTube. You can take a look at our channel if you are interested.



Come to the seaside in Jastarnia | Slow Chinese | HSK 3



3 reasons why you may never learn Chinese

WATCH & LISTEN

Mandarin Zest on YouTube

youtube.com/@ChineseMandarinZest

LESSON 04 · HSK TESTS

HSK TESTS ARE SOOOOO OVERRATED!

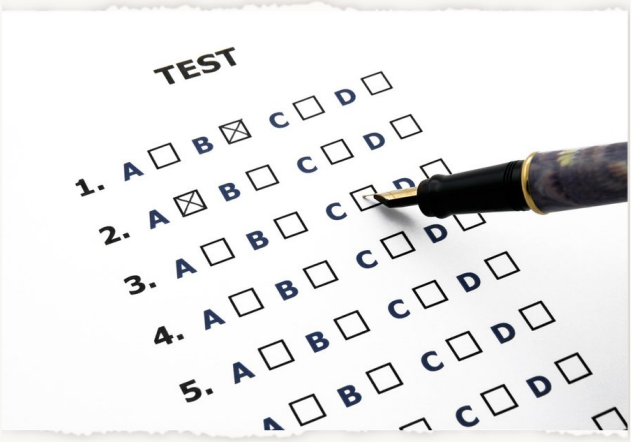
04

KEY TAKEAWAY

Passing HSK tests and actually knowing Chinese are two different things. Choose the latter.

Don't get me wrong: I do not discourage you from taking the HSK tests. **If you already passed one, congratulations!**

I passed HSK 4 and 5, and I know they are good at **making you motivated.** However, I don't think they are a good indicator of your Chinese level in general.



What I learned from mock tests

When I was preparing for HSK 5 years ago, I took a lot of mock tests. I realized I should not read any text there or even listen to what they are saying. **Just find the keywords and look for the answers.**

In my opinion, HSK tests are just very **poorly designed.** I have a good comparison, since I took other language tests (for context, I speak 5).

PREPARING FOR AN HSK TEST?

Prioritize mock tests.

Just find the keywords and look for the answers.

WANT TO SPEAK ACTUAL CHINESE?

Prioritize everything else.

HSK tests don't measure actual language comprehension very well.

WHAT HSK TESTS ARE GOOD FOR

- Motivating yourself
- Learning a lot of vocabulary in a short period of time

WHAT THEY DON'T MEASURE WELL

- Actual language comprehension
- Your ability to hold a real conversation

> **You can pass an HSK exam and still be barely able to speak.**

Allow me a small self-promo: if you are looking for HSK-friendly materials, we offer great resources here.



New HSK 1



New HSK 2



New HSK 3

LESSON 05 · COMMUNITY

05

NO MOTIVATION? YOU PROBABLY LACK COMMUNITY SUPPORT.

KEY TAKEAWAY

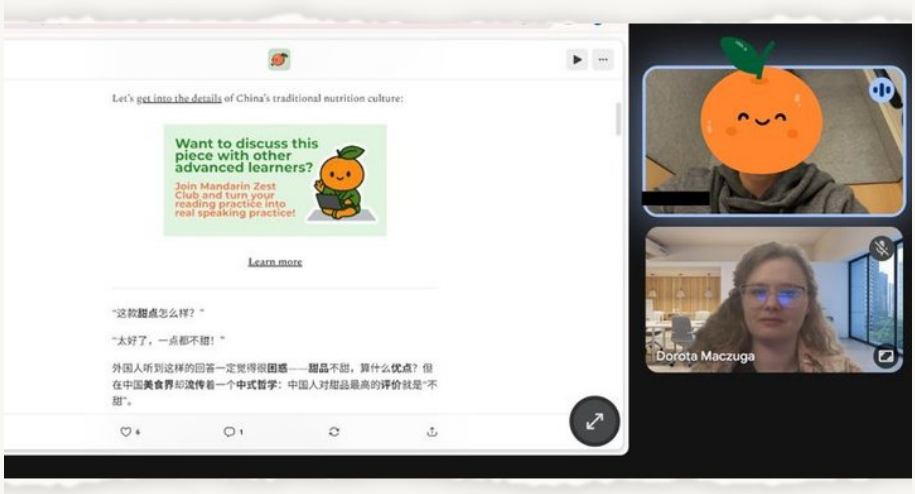
Speak with others. It is the best way to get motivated and stay motivated.

If your goal is to actually speak through conversation practice but you often don't feel motivated, **you probably lack community support.**

When I started learning Chinese, I did it with friends. **It has always been very important for me to speak with others.**

This is why I run study sessions at the **Mandarin Zest Club**: to get motivated and stay motivated. **If you want to practise with us, reach out to us!**





A Mandarin Zest Club session online.

练

PRACTISE WITH US

Join the Mandarin Zest Club

mandarinzest.com/mandarin-zest-club

Thank you for reading!

Thank you so much for reading my guide. I hope you found my tips useful and are now **more motivated than ever to master your Chinese.**

If you have any questions, feel free to contact me on Instagram or by e-mail.



谢谢

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